Excel
INTERVIEWER-STYLE PRACTICE

Fresher Data Analyst | English answers + Hindi explanations + practical examples + follow-up cross questions

20 interview scenarios | Practice answering aloud | Use only project details you have actually verified

How to practice

Read the question first and answer aloud before reading the model answer. Learn the concept, not just the wording. For syntax, mention that exact functions may vary by tool or database version. For project questions, describe only work you personally completed.

Interviewer Q1: How would you find an employee's department using employee ID?

Suggested English answer: I can use XLOOKUP to search the ID column and return the department column, with a not-found message.

Hindi me samjho: Employee ID lookup karke department return karunga.

```
Practical example:
=XLOOKUP(A2,Employees[ID],Employees[Department],"Not found")
```

Interviewer follow-up: What if XLOOKUP is unavailable?

How to answer: Use VLOOKUP if return column is to the right, or INDEX-MATCH.

Interviewer Q2: Explain VLOOKUP and its common limitation.

Suggested English answer: VLOOKUP searches the first column of a range and returns a value to its right. Column insertion can make fixed index numbers fragile.

Hindi me samjho: VLOOKUP first column me search karke right-side result deta hai; fixed column index fragile ho sakta hai.

```
Practical example:
=VLOOKUP(A2,$H$2:$J$100,3,FALSE)
```

Interviewer follow-up: Why use FALSE?

How to answer: It requests an exact match, which is generally expected for IDs.

Interviewer Q3: What is XLOOKUP's advantage?

Suggested English answer: It separates lookup and return arrays, supports left or right returns, exact match by default, and a not-found result.

Hindi me samjho: Lookup aur return ranges alag; left/right dono possible.

```
Practical example:
=XLOOKUP(A2,H:H,J:J,"Not found")
```

Interviewer follow-up: Can it work in every Excel version?

How to answer: No, availability depends on version; check compatibility.

Interviewer Q4: How would you calculate total sales for West region?

Suggested English answer: Use SUMIF for one criterion or SUMIFS when multiple criteria are needed.

Hindi me samjho: West region ki sales sum karne ke liye SUMIF/SUMIFS.

```
Practical example:
=SUMIF(B:B,"West",E:E)
```

Interviewer follow-up: How would you add a year criterion?

How to answer: Use SUMIFS with region and year criteria ranges.

Interviewer Q5: Explain IF and IFERROR.

Suggested English answer: IF returns one result for true and another for false. IFERROR returns a fallback if a formula errors.

Hindi me samjho: IF condition result; IFERROR error aane par fallback.

```
Practical example:
=IF(C2>=3000,"Target met","Below target")
```

Interviewer follow-up: Can IF be nested?

How to answer: Yes, but IFS or lookup tables may be easier to maintain for many categories.

Interviewer Q6: What is a PivotTable?

Suggested English answer: It summarizes rows by categories using aggregations like sum, count, and average, without building separate formulas for each group.

Hindi me samjho: Region-wise sales ya product-wise count quickly summarize karta hai.

Interviewer follow-up: What should you check before creating it?

How to answer: Headers, consistent data types, no merged header cells, and a clean rectangular source range.

Interviewer Q7: How do you create an interactive Excel dashboard?

Suggested English answer: Prepare clean source tables, create PivotTables and charts, add slicers, highlight a few KPIs, and validate totals and filters.

Hindi me samjho: Clean data → PivotTable → charts → slicers → KPI cards → validation.

Interviewer follow-up: What makes a dashboard readable?

How to answer: Clear titles, consistent units, limited colors, useful comparisons, and no unnecessary clutter.

Interviewer Q8: How do you identify duplicate IDs?

Suggested English answer: Use Conditional Formatting or COUNTIF to flag repeated IDs, then inspect before removing.

Hindi me samjho: COUNTIF/conditional formatting se duplicate ID flag karunga.

```
Practical example:
=COUNTIF($A:$A,A2)>1
```

Interviewer follow-up: Would you delete duplicates immediately?

How to answer: No. Confirm the key and which record should be retained first.

Interviewer Q9: How do you clean extra spaces?

Suggested English answer: TRIM removes extra ordinary spaces; CLEAN removes many non-printing characters. Check nonbreaking spaces separately if needed.

Hindi me samjho: TRIM extra spaces aur CLEAN non-printing characters clean karta hai.

```
Practical example:
=TRIM(CLEAN(A2))
```

Interviewer follow-up: Why might TRIM not remove every visible space?

How to answer: Some imported text uses nonbreaking spaces, which may require SUBSTITUTE.

Interviewer Q10: Explain absolute and relative references.

Suggested English answer: A1 adjusts when copied; $A$1 locks both row and column; $A1 or A$1 locks one dimension.

Hindi me samjho: Relative copy par change; dollar sign row/column lock karta hai.

Interviewer follow-up: When is $ useful?

How to answer: When copying a formula while keeping a tax rate or lookup range fixed.

Interviewer Q11: How do you calculate percentage achievement?

Suggested English answer: Divide actual by target and format as percentage, handling zero targets safely.

Hindi me samjho: Actual/target karke percentage format; zero target handle karo.

```
Practical example:
=IFERROR(B2/C2,0)
```

Interviewer follow-up: What does 120% mean?

How to answer: Actual is 1.2 times the target, or 20% above target.

Interviewer Q12: What is Power Query in Excel?

Suggested English answer: It imports and transforms data through repeatable steps, useful for recurring monthly files and cleaning.

Hindi me samjho: Monthly files ko repeatable steps se combine/clean karne ke liye.

Interviewer follow-up: Why is it useful for monthly reporting?

How to answer: New files can follow the same transformation process after refresh, if structure is consistent.

Interviewer Q13: How do you use conditional formatting in business?

Suggested English answer: Highlight overdue dates, low stock, negative margins, or top performers using clear rules.

Hindi me samjho: Low stock red, overdue dates highlight, top values mark kar sakte hain.

Interviewer follow-up: Can formatting replace analysis?

How to answer: No. It highlights patterns; the underlying values and business definition still need checking.

Interviewer Q14: How do you prevent incorrect data entry?

Suggested English answer: Use Data Validation lists, allowed ranges, clear headers, and input instructions.

Hindi me samjho: Dropdown/range validation se incorrect entry kam hoti hai.

Interviewer follow-up: Is sheet protection the same as security?

How to answer: No. It mainly helps prevent accidental edits; protect sensitive files through access controls.

Interviewer Q15: How would you check a report before sending it?

Suggested English answer: Reconcile totals to source, test filters, check formulas and ranges, inspect blanks/duplicates, and verify sample rows.

Hindi me samjho: Source total, formulas, filters, blanks/duplicates aur sample rows check karunga.

Interviewer follow-up: What if totals do not match?

How to answer: Check date ranges, hidden filters, duplicate records, formula range boundaries, and metric definitions.

Interviewer Q16: What is the difference between sorting and filtering?

Suggested English answer: Sorting changes row order; filtering displays only records meeting selected conditions.

Hindi me samjho: Sort order change; filter matching rows show karta hai.

Interviewer follow-up: Does filtering delete rows?

How to answer: No, it hides nonmatching rows from view.

Interviewer Q17: How do you split full names?

Suggested English answer: Use Text to Columns, Flash Fill, or text functions depending on consistency and Excel version.

Hindi me samjho: Name ko first/last me split karne ke liye Text to Columns/Flash Fill.

Interviewer follow-up: What if names contain middle names?

How to answer: Define a consistent rule and inspect exceptions; a simple split may not represent every name correctly.

Interviewer Q18: How would you summarize monthly sales by region?

Suggested English answer: Create a PivotTable with month in rows, region in columns, and sales as Sum; add a date grouping or helper month field if needed.

Hindi me samjho: Rows me month, columns me region, values me Sum of Sales.

Interviewer follow-up: Why use year and month together?

How to answer: To avoid combining January from different years.

Interviewer Q19: What would you do if a lookup returns #N/A?

Suggested English answer: Check exact key, leading/trailing spaces, data types, missing ID, and lookup range; use IFNA only after diagnosing.

Hindi me samjho: Key, spaces, data type aur range check karunga; error ko bina reason hide nahi karunga.

Interviewer follow-up: How can text-number mismatch cause problems?

How to answer: An ID stored as text may not match the same-looking numeric value.

Interviewer Q20: Explain how Excel supports a Data Analyst.

Suggested English answer: I use Excel for quick inspection, cleaning, formulas, lookups, pivot summaries, and reconciliation alongside SQL, Python, and Power BI.

Hindi me samjho: Excel initial checking, cleaning, formulas, pivot aur validation me help karta hai.

Interviewer follow-up: When would you move work to SQL or Python?

How to answer: For repeatable large-scale transformations, multi-table extraction, automation, and version-controlled workflows.

Final interview reminder: Pause, clarify the requirement, explain your approach, and validate the result. It is acceptable to say you would verify a detail rather than guess.